Bronze icons on display

MADRAS

In the sharply etched symmetry of features nd form, the flexions of body and limbs and ie representation of rhythm and movement, the ronzes of South India exemplify the acme of erfection of a highly evolved and consummate rt. In these exquisite bronze icons, poetry is rrested in motion, poise and grace caught in fleeting moment of time for all eternity. And s in other Indian art forms, it was always the uman body and its manifold emotions which rovided the sculptor in bronze the source of is inspiration. But in these images of deities, ie physical and the corporeal are transcended sublimation. Since the bronzes were objects f worship, work itself became worship for the culptors who adhering to the strict injunctions f the silpa sastras invested their creations with feeling of the godly and reverential.

Though bronzes were made in the Pallava eriod circa eighth century A.D., it was the hola period, the tenth century in particular, hich saw the efflorescence of this art.

Impressive exhibits: An impressive exhibition f the bronzes of Tamil Nadu has been orgaised by Poompuhar (The Tamil Nadu Handicrafts Development Corporation Limited) at the ankara Hall, Mowbrays Road. The exhibition, naugurated by the Governor, Dr. P. C. Alexnder, on Friday offers a choice replication of ie classic bronzes of Tamil Nadu, and is open ll December 15 (11 a.m. to 7 p.m.). Various anifestations of Siva, Sakti and Ganesha, enugopala, Kalyana Sundara, Vishnu are all epresented here in varying sizes with each minte detail intact. Images of Ardhanareeswara ombining equal attributes of Siva and Sakti, ie cosmic dancer Nataraja, the serene-faced ishabhadeva have been faithfully produced rom ancient sculpture.

Though purists may be averse to innovations s in the figure of Ganesha with umbrella and undala and on the reclining couch in Grecoioman fashion, these do find a ready market ccording to the organisers. A beautiful figure s that of the statesque Lakshmi with graceful ngers encircling the imaginary pot of nectar orrowed from the suggestive idiom of a dancer.

Elaborate process: Says S. Sarangan who as been making bronze icons for more than quarter of a century, "The casting of the icons s an elaborate process requiring total knowidge of the craft and great care and precision. o make an icon first beeswax and "kongilyam" are mixed and added to water to make he wax for the mould. The different parts — rms, legs, torso, etc. are made separately and hen joined together. Decorative work is then hisied on. The wax image is covered with fine ver sand to the thickness of paper. Then clay nd river sand mixed together are coated on the obverse side of the mould.

"The whole figure is dried in the sun. When ompletely dry, the process is repeated on the onverse side. The image is heated and the wax ows out from a hole near the feet. The sand



image mould is then heated and molten panchaloha (copper, zinc, lead, tin and gold optional) is poured into the mould. When it cools the mould is broken with a hammer and the rough figure obtained. It is polished and embellished. It takes 15 days to make a 30 cm high figure."

Mr. Badrinath, Managing Director of Poompuhar, whose artistic sensibility pervades the exhibition says, it is the first time such an exclusive collection of bronzes is exhibited in the city. The general misconception is that these bronzes are just objects of art. Each one of them is a representation of cosmic energy. In ancient Indian civilisation, clay, metal, stone and even grass was invested with energy, beauty and meaning and in turn they gave man beauty, energy and meaning increased a thousandfold and are now a part of our consciousness.

Helping artisans: "What we are trying to achieve in the Corporation is to employ the handicrafts of Tamil Nadu to create gentler feelings in society, convey aesthetic awareness and artistic sensitivity. Our aim is to ameliorate the artisans who though the creators of such sublimal beauty are in appalling conditions of poverty.

The Crafts Council of India engaged by Poompuhar has organised the display with taste and skill, the only false note being the use of thatched roofs for the display, suitable perhaps for an exhibition of terracotta or other rural handicrafts but inappropriate one feels, for this highly evolved art form.

According to Mr. T. V. Antony, Chairman of the Tamil Nadu Handicrafts Corporation, it has plans to make objects combining beauty and utility. He says, "objects of beauty should have utility as well for them to find a ready market with the economy-conscious middle class."



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